Listen Lord, The Creation and Prodigal Son

By James Weldon Johnson

INTRODUCTION

The poet and civil rights activist, James Weldon Johnson was influenced by his impressions of the rural South. His interest in the African-American folk tradition was ignited and resulted in a collection of "sermons" entitled God's Trombones. It is said that Johnson considered the voice of the black preacher to be a musical instrument "not a piano . . . or trumpet but a trombone. From the printed page, peals the roar of the black preacher delivering a rousing sermon. The ability of Johnson to capture the sense of deliverance from the trials and tribulations of everyday life is indeed a talent. Listen Lord, The Creation and Prodigal Son by James Weldon Johnson from the anthology God's Trombones.

LISTEN LORD

O Lord, we come this morning

Knee-bowed and body-bent

Before thy throne of grace.

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O Lord - this morning

Bow our hearts beneath our knees,

And our knees in some lonesome valley.

We come this morning

Like empty pitchers to a full fountain,

With no merits of our own.

O Lord - open up a window of heaven,

And lean out far over the battlements of glory,

And listen this morning.

Lord, have mercy on proud and dying sinners

Sinners hanging over the mouth of hell,

Who seem to love their distance well.

Lord - ride by this morning

Mount your milk-white horse,

And ride-a this morning

And in your ride, ride by old hell,

Ride by the dingy gates of hell,

And stop poor sinners in their headlong plunge.

And now, O Lord, this man of God,

Who breaks the bread of life this morning

Shadow him in the hollow of thy hand,

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And keep him out of the gunshot of the devil.
Take him, Lord - this morning
Wash him with hyssop inside and out,
Hang him up and drain him dry of sin.
Pin his ear to the wisdom-post,
And make his words sledge hammers of truth
Beating on the iron heart of sin.
Lord God, this morning
Put his eye to the telescope of eternity,
And let him look upon the paper walls of time.
Lord, turpentine his imagination,
Put perpetual motion in his arms,
Fill him full of the dynamite of thy power,
Anoint him all over with the oil of thy salvation,
And set his tongue on fire.
And now, O Lord
When I've done drunk my last cup of sorrow
When I've been called everything but a child of God
When I'm done travelling up the rough side of the mountain
O Mary's Baby

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When I start down the steep and slippery steps of death
When this old world begins to rock beneath my feet -
Lower me to my dusty grave in peace
To wait for that great gittin' up morning - Amen.

THE CREATION

And God stepped out on space,
And he looked around and said:
I'm lonely -
I'll make me a world.
And far as the eye of God could see
Darkness covered everything,
Blacker than a hundred midnights
Down in a cypress swamp.
Then God smiled,
And the light broke,

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And the darkness rolled up on one side,
And the light stood shining on the other,
And God said: That's good!
Then God reached out and took the light in his hands,
And God rolled the light around in his hands
Until he made the sun;
And he set that sun a-blazing in the heavens.
And the light that was left from making the sun
God gathered it up in a shining ball
And flung it against the darkness,
Spangling the night with the moon and stars.
Then down between
The darkness and the light
He hurled the world;
And God said: That's good!
Then God himself stepped down -
And the sun was on his right hand,
And the moon was on his left;
The stars were clustered about his head,
And the earth was under his feet.
And God walked, and where he trod

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His footsteps hollowed the valleys out
And bulged the mountains up.
Then he stopped and looked and saw
That the earth was hot and barren.
So God stepped over to the edge of the world
And he spat out the seven seas -
He batted his eyes, and the lightnings flashed -
He clapped his hands, and the thunders rolled -
And the waters above the earth came down,
The cooling waters came down.
Then the green grass sprouted,
And the little red flowers blossomed,
The pine tree pointed his finger to the sky,
And the oak spread out his arms,
The lakes cuddled down in the hollows of the ground,
And the rivers ran down to the sea;
And God smiled again,
And the rainbow appeared,
And curled itself around his shoulder.
The God raised his arm and he waved his hand
Over the sea and over the land,

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And he said: Bring forth! Bring forth!
And quicker than God could drop his hand,
Fishes and fowls
And beasts and birds
Swam the rivers and the seas,
Roamed the forests and the woods,
And split the air with their wings.
And God said: That's good!
Then God walked around,
And God looked around
On all that he had made.
He looked at his sun,
And he looked at his moon,
And he looked at his little stars;
He looked on his world
With all its living things,
And God said: I'm lonely still.
Then God sat down -
On the side of a hill where he could think;
By a deep, wide river he sat down;
With his head in his hands,

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God thought and thought,
Till he thought: I'll make me a man!
Up from the bed of the river
God scooped the clay;
And by the bank of the river
He kneeled him down;
And there the great God Almighty
Who lit the sun and fixed it in the sky,
Who flung the stars to the most far corner of the night,
Who rounded the earth in the middle of his hand;
This Great God,
Like a mammy bending over her baby,
Kneeled down in the dust
Toiling over a lump of clay
Till he shaped it in his own image;
Then into it he blew the breath of life,
And man became a living soul.
Amen. Amen.

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THE PRODIGAL SON

Young man Young man

Your arm's too short to box with God. B

ut Jesus spake in a parable, and he said:

A certain man had two sons.

Jesus didn't give this man a name,

But his name is God Almighty.

And Jesus didn't call these sons by name,

But ev'ry young man,

Ev'rywhere,

Is one of these two sons.

And the younger son said to his father,

He said: Father, divide up the property,

And give me my portion now.

And the father with tears in his eyes said: Son,

Don't leave your father's house.

But the boy was stubborn in his head,

And haughty in his heart,

And he took his share of his father's goods,

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And went into a far-off country.

There comes a time,

There comes a time

When ev'ry young man looks out from his father's house,

Longing for that far-off country.

And the young man journeyed on his way,

And he said to himself as he travelled along:

This sure is an easy road,

Nothing like the rough furrows behind my father's plow.

Young man

Young man

Smooth and easy is the road

That leads to hell and destruction.

Down grade all the way,

The further you travel, the faster you go.

No need to trudge and sweat and toil,

Just slip and slide and slip and slide

Till you bang up against hell's iron gate.

And the younger son kept travelling along,

Till at night-time he came to a city.

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And the city was bright in the night-time like day, The streets all crowded with people,
Brass bands and string bands a-playing,
And ev'rywhere the young man turned
There was singing and laughing and dancing.
And he stopped a passer-by and he said:
Tell me what city is this?
And the passer-by laughed and said: Don't you know?
This is Babylon, Babylon,
That great city of Babylon.
Come on, my friend, and go along with me.
And the young man joined the crowd.
Young man
Young man
You're never lonesome in Babylon.
You can always join a crowd in Babylon.
Young man
Young man
You can never be alone in Babylon,
Alone with your Jesus in Babylon.

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You can never find a place, a lonesome place,
A lonesome place to go down on your knees,
And talk with your God, in Babylon.
You're always in a crowd in Babylon.
And the young man went with his new-found friend, And bought himself some brand new clothes,
And he spent his days in the drinking dens, Swallowing the fires of hell.
And he spent his nights in the gambling dens,

Throwing dice with the devil for his soul.
And he met up with the women of Babylon.
Oh, the women of Babylon!
Dressed in yellow and purple and scarlet, Loaded with rings and earrings and bracelets, Their lips like a honeycomb dripping with honey, Perfumed and sweet-smelling like a jasmine flower; And the jasmine smell of the Babylon women Got in his nostrils and went to his head,
And he wasted his substance in riotous living,

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In the evening, in the black and dark of night, With the sweet-sinning women of Babylon.
And they stripped him of his money,
And they stripped him of his clothes,
And they left him broke and ragged
In the streets of Babylon.
Then the young man joined another crowd The beggars and lepers of Babylon.
And he went to feeding swine,
And he was hungrier than the hogs;
He got down on his belly in the mire and mud And ate the husks with the hogs.
And not a hog was too low to turn up his nose At the man in the mire of Babylon.
Then the young man came to himself
He came to himself and said:
In my father's house are many mansions,
Ev'ry servant in his house has bread to eat, Ev'ry servant in his house has a place to sleep; I will arise and go to my father.

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And his father saw him afar off,
And he ran up the road to meet him.
He put clean clothes upon his back,
And a golden chain around his neck,
He made a feast and killed the fatted calf,
And invited the neighbors in.
Oh-o-oh, sinner,
When you're mingling with the crowd in BabylonDrinking the wine of Babylon
Running with the women of Babylon
You forget about God, and you laugh at Death. Today you've got the strength of a bull in your neck And the strength of a bear in your arms,
But some 0' these days, some 0' these days,
You'll have a hand-to-hand struggle with bony Death,
And Death is bound to win.
Young man, come away from Babylon,
That hell-border city of Babylon.
Leave the dancing and gambling of Babylon,
The wine and whiskey of Babylon,
The hot-mouthed women of Babylon;

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Fall down on your knees,

And say in your heart:

I will arise and go to my Father.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: James Weldon Johnson
Book: God's Trombones
ISBN: 978-0140184037
Publisher: Penguin Books
Date(Month/Year): Feb 1990

AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier

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